

Helene is bringing 'life-threatening flash flooding' to North Carolina.

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FULL TEXT

In Western North Carolina, heavy rains are causing rivers and lakes to overflow, and landslides have blocked major roads. Across the state, two deaths have been linked to the storm.

As Tropical Storm Helene pounds North Carolina, the western part of the state is being hit hardest, with heavy rains causing rivers and lakes to overflow and landslides blocking major roads. Across the state, two deaths have been linked to the storm.

Gov. Roy Cooper warned on Friday of "life-threatening flash flooding" along with landslides and power outages because of downed trees, particularly in the foothills and mountains of Western North Carolina.

"With the rain that they had already been experiencing before Helene's arrival, this is one of the worst storms in modern history for parts of western North Carolina," Mr. Cooper said.

"The priority now is saving lives."

Two deaths have been linked to the storm. A 4-year-old girl died in Catawba County in a motor vehicle collision, and another person died in Charlotte when a tree fell on a home.

Across the state, there were more than 875,000 power outages and 290 closed roads by Friday morning, according to the governor. Swift water rescue teams had carried out more than 100 rescues.

Officials said they expected rains to continue to lash the state through Saturday but warned that the risk of major flooding would last longer.

"Do not travel unless there is an emergency," Mr. Cooper said. "Consider all roads closed unless you're seeking higher ground."

In Western North Carolina, rivers and at least one lake overflowed and landslides closed spots of Interstate 40 and several major roads, while many waterways had spilled over.

In Rutherford County, between Asheville and Charlotte, the National Weather Service and county officials warned of an imminent failure at Lake Lure Dam. Residents downstream were told around noon on Friday to "evacuate to higher ground immediately!"

In Buncombe County, which includes Asheville, dozens of water rescues had been carried out by Friday morning, and four people were missing after a landslide, according to county officials.

They warned the worst could be yet to come. "Our rivers have not yet crested," Avril Pinder, the Buncombe County manager, said in a news briefing Friday morning. "This will get worse."

Haywood County, around 35 miles west of the city of Asheville, is reportedly seeing some of the worst flooding in the area. According to The Mountaineer, the police in the city of Waynesville reported a backlog of 200 incoming 911 calls shortly after 10 a.m. Friday.

DETAILS

Subject:	Landslides & mudslides; Storm damage; Floods; Evacuations & rescues; Rain
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Location:	United States--US; North Carolina
Identifier / keyword:	Hurricane Helene (2024); Landslides and Mudslides; Floods; Rain; North Carolina; Asheville (NC); Charlotte (NC); Haywood County (NC)
Publication title:	New York Times (Online); New York
Publication year:	2024
Publication date:	Sep 27, 2024
Section:	weather
Publisher:	New York Times Company
Place of publication:	New York
Country of publication:	United States
Publication subject:	General Interest Periodicals--United States
e-ISSN:	15538095
Source type:	Blog, Podcast, or Website
Language of publication:	English
Document type:	News
ProQuest document ID:	3110386529
Document URL:	http://libproxy.lib.unc.edu/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/blogs-podcasts-websites/helene-is-bringing-life-threatening-flash/docview/3110386529/se-2?accountid=14244
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Last updated:	2024-09-27
Database:	ProQuest Central

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